



W. Asia

Great Mosque of Samarra

One of the world's largest mosques, and a spectacular example of early Islamic architecture and ingenuity

Samarra, on the east bank of Iraq's Tigris River, north of Baghdad, was the 9th-century capital of the powerful Abbasid caliphate (the Muslim political and religious state). The town is especially famous for its Great Mosque, with its spectacular spiral minaret. Constructed between c.848 and 852 CE—during the Islamic golden age—by the caliph al-Mutawakkil, it is considered an important example of early Islamic architecture.

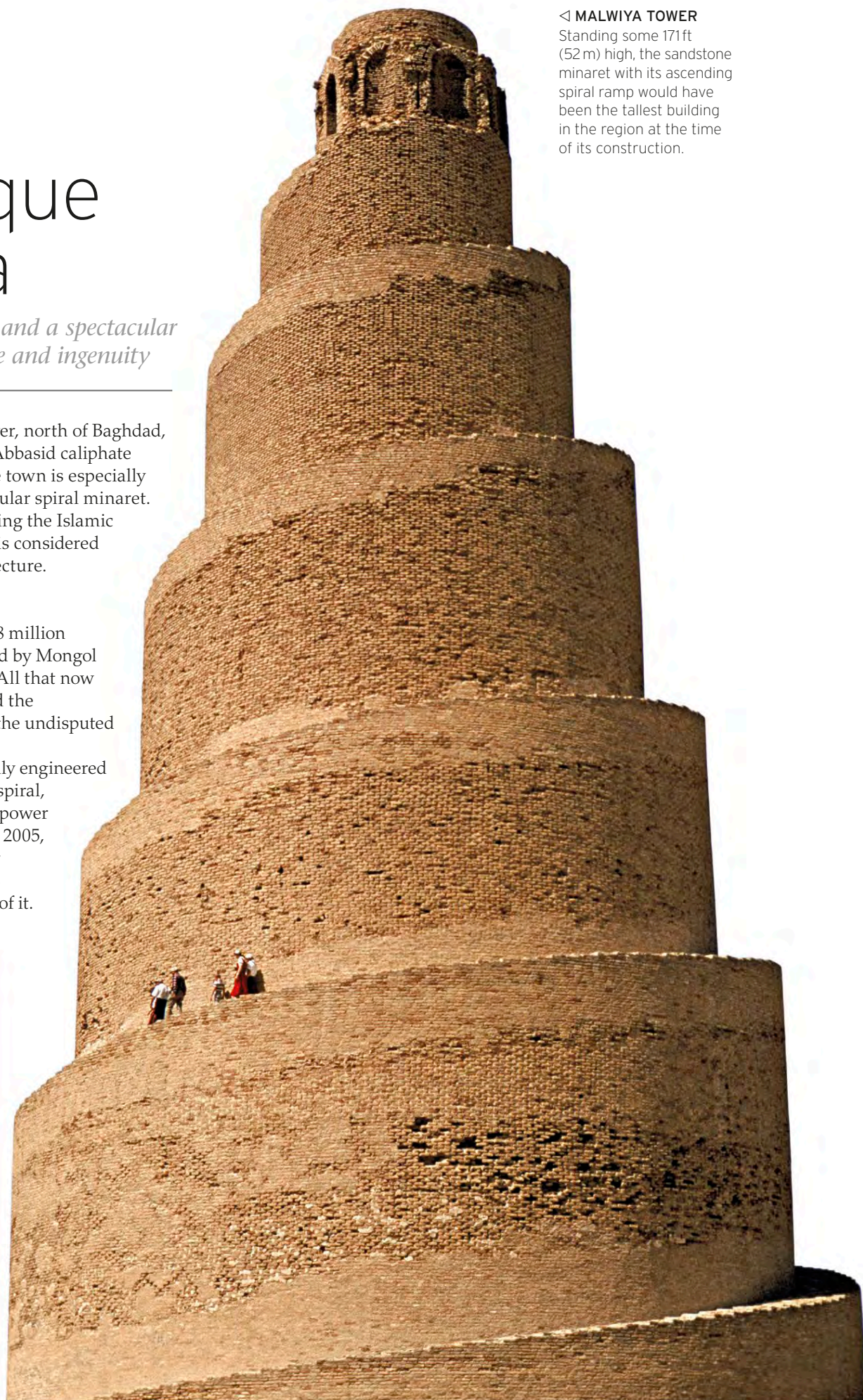
Snail shell tower

The mosque originally extended over some 1.8 million square ft (170,000 square m) but was damaged by Mongol armies during their invasion of Iraq in 1278. All that now remains of the mosque are its outer walls and the magnificent Malwiya ("snail shell") Tower—the undisputed highlight of the ancient site.

Combining science and artistry, the skillfully engineered tower is notable for its distinctive conical, or spiral, shape. It served as a forceful reminder of the power of the caliphate and the presence of Islam. In 2005, it became the subject of global attention after insurgents, having discovered that US troops were using it as a lookout post, bombed part of it.

◀ MALWIYA TOWER

Standing some 171 ft (52 m) high, the sandstone minaret with its ascending spiral ramp would have been the tallest building in the region at the time of its construction.



LAYOUT AND FEATURES

The mosque is rectangular in shape and enclosed by a 33-ft- (10-m-) high brick wall, which includes 44 semicircular towers. It also featured 16 entrance gates, walls lined with dark-blue glass mosaics, 17 aisles, and a courtyard surrounded by an arcade. The minaret sits next to the mosque and was originally connected to it by a bridge.

